AMARINDER COMES WITH THE BAGGAGE OF ANTI-INCUMBENCY BUT HE CAN ALSO HELP BJP SPLIT THE CONGRESS VOTE

Sikh consolidation, a better option for them than sharing power with the Hindutva-oriented BJP. In the past six months, Sukhbir has also managed to bring most of the splinter groups of the Akali Dal back into the party fold, including those led by Ranjit Singh Bhrampura, Rattan Singh Ajnala and Ujagar Singh Wadali. He has accommodated panthic leaders like Prem Singh Chandumajra, Tota Singh and Sikander Singh Maluka by inducting their sons, whether by giving them tickets or by appointing them in the party's organisational set-up. These moves have strengthened SAD's hold over its traditional panthic voters.

The reason Sukhbir believes SAD could win is because "more than any other party, we have the best organisation" and the fact that SAD "is the only true Punjabi party". That is a point he hammers home in the small gatherings of traders and businessmen at Mandi Gobindgarh. He attacks Kejriwal saying that the Delhi CM is trying to impose a franchise model unsuited to Punjab. He also emphasises a potential conflict of interest—Kejriwal wants the Sutlej Yamuna Link Canal to bring water to Delhi, to the detriment of Punjab. He ends by promising to take development to the next level and make it easy to do business. Besides AAP and the farmer unions, it now has a new challenger in the urban seats: the BJP and its allies. So Sukhbir is using all possible means to neutralise that by wooing the Hindus: he has given tickets to 35 Hindu candidates. Sukhbir's advantage is that he has kicked off his campaign much earlier than the other parties after having firmed up ticket distribution. Like a good CEO, Sukhbir is reportedly also preparing for all eventualities, and that includes eyeing post-election allies in the event of a hung house.

Amarinder: His Last Stand

Politics can make strange bedfellows. Amarinder, with his 14-year-long detour through Akali politics post 1984, is no monochrome politician but even he would have been surprised at the path his life took last September. First, a demotion from chief ministership, then a complete ouster from the Congress party. The parting was acrimonious: a bruised captain had lashed out at the Gandhis, accusing them of betraying him and treating him like a piece of furniture. Months later, at his sprawling mansion on the outskirts of Chandigarh, quite the royal affair with softly gurgling fountains, a swimming pool and the model of a yesteryear Jaguar with a tabletop for sundowners on the balcony, Amarinder seemed more composed. "I don't feel the betrayal anymore, but they weren't able to judge me properly and that's what puts me off. They didn't realise that I still had something to give the country and if I could do it, why I should quit." That hurt drew him to form his own party, the Punjab Lok Congress, at 79 years of age, and to ally with the BJP.

So why didn't he just join the BJP? Amarinder's candid reply: "I felt that secularism has been the background in our family and I told Amit Shahji



PUNJAB LOK CONGRESS

STRENGTHS

- Its alliance with the BJP, which will help it win support from Hindu voters
- Amarinder Singh is well thought of among moderate Sikhs
- Can play 'double engine sarkar' card, given its alliance with BJP
- Could benefit from the repeal of the BJP's controversial farm laws